



TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY MEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

WEEK 12

Date: Supervisor:

Project / Job Name:

TOPIC: Random Orbital & Belt Sander Safety

OVERVIEW:

Sanders are used constantly in finish carpentry for surface preparation, fitting, and final finishing. The fine dust they produce is a significant respiratory hazard, a fire hazard, and — in the case of MDF and exotic hardwoods — a known carcinogen. Dust control is not optional. It is a core part of safe

TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. The most important safety step before sanding is connecting dust collection. A random orbital sander without a connected vacuum can put 90% of the dust it generates into the air around you. Breathe that air for months or years and you are dramatically increasing your risk of respiratory disease. Connect the vacuum, check the bag or canister, and replace the filter when it is dirty.
2. For MDF sanding specifically, an N95 dust mask is the absolute minimum protection — a P100 half-face respirator is strongly preferred. MDF dust contains urea-formaldehyde and is classified as a probable carcinogen. The particles are also extremely fine, which means they penetrate deeper into the lungs than coarser wood dust. If you are sanding MDF for extended periods, you need real
3. Sawdust accumulation is a fire hazard. Fine dry wood dust ignites easily and burns fast. Never allow dust to accumulate on ledges, motor housings, electrical panels, or near any ignition source. At the end of every day, clean up dust with a vacuum — not compressed air, which disperses the fine particles into the air and can create an explosive dust cloud in a confined space.
4. When using a belt sander, keep the tool moving at all times. Stopping a running belt sander in one place creates a tremendous amount of heat in a very short time, scorching the wood and burning through the abrasive belt. Keep firm, consistent two-hand control and move in the direction of the grain. When setting the sander down between uses, lay it on its side — never set a running sander

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

- Q1: Where is our dust collection equipment on this site and what is the condition of the filters?
Q2: What types of wood are we working with right now that require extra respiratory protection?

KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Connect dust collection before sanding — fine dust accumulates rapidly
- Wear an N95 respirator minimum; P100 for MDF or exotic wood dust
- Secure the workpiece so both hands can control the sander safely
- Inspect sanding discs and belts — torn abrasives can grab and throw material
- Keep belt sander moving — stopping creates burn marks and heat buildup

Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.



CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 12

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

#	PRINT NAME	SIGNATURE (click to sign in Acrobat)	#	PRINT NAME	SIGNATURE (click to sign in Acrobat)
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